

PART 3

SAFE DRIVING TIPS

CHAPTER 8 / DEFENSIVE DRIVING

Most drivers are good drivers. But even the best drivers make errors now and then. Equipment fails, weather conditions can be bad, and some drivers ignore traffic laws or drive in an erratic manner. To prevent making errors or being involved in a crash because of someone else's error, learn to drive in a defensive manner:

- Be prepared and look ahead.
- Maintain the correct speed.
- Signal before you turn or change lanes.
- Allow space.
- Wear your seat belt.
- Do not drive if you are very weary, are on medication or have been drinking beverages that contain alcohol.
- Keep your vehicle in good condition.
- Do not use hand held mobile devices while driving.

BE PREPARED AND LOOK AHEAD

You should sit in a comfortable but vertical position and keep both hands on the steering wheel. Slouching in the driver's seat or using only one hand on the wheel makes it more difficult or even dangerous to control your vehicle.

Traffic conditions change continuously. Always scan the road ahead. Do not use the road or even the vehicle ahead as your only points of focus. Look ahead so you can prevent, or decrease, possible problems.

Keep your eyes moving, notice what is happening at the sides of the road, and check behind you through your mirrors every few seconds.

Anticipate errors by other drivers, bicyclists and pedestrians and think about what you will do if an error occurs. Do not assume that a driver who approaches a STOP or YIELD sign on a side road is actually going to stop or yield. It is better to assume the other driver will not stop.

DRIVER DISTRACTIONS

A distraction is anything that takes your attention away from driving. Distracted driving can cause crashes, resulting in injury, death, or property damage. Taking your eyes off the road or hands off the steering wheel presents obvious driving risks. Mental activities that take your mind away from driving are just as dangerous.

When driving:

- Do not use cell phones or text.
- Avoid arguments and stressful or emotional conversations with passengers.
- Avoid eating while driving.
- Be sure children are properly and safely restrained.
- Properly secure pets in a pet carrier or portable kennel.

You must pay attention to the driving task. You are responsible for operating your vehicle in a safe manner.

AGGRESSIVE DRIVERS

Aggressive driving includes speeding, which often leads to following too closely, frequent or quick lane changes without a signal, passing on the shoulder or parts of the roadway that are not paved or being a nuisance to motorists, bicyclists or pedestrians, who don't get out of the way. Aggressive drivers sometimes run stop signs and